

Southern Flames

Companion Workbook

Exercises, wine pairings, and service scenarios
drawn from each of the twelve chapters.

Answers at the back.

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

SUPPLEMENTAL MATERIAL

Southern Flames and this workbook are supplemental to the ServeMaster Academy course and app. The novel brings the skills to life through story; the app is where you practise, certify, and track your progress. Use both together for the full experience.

Each chapter has three parts:

Knowledge Check

Four multiple-choice questions on wine, service technique, and the chapter setting. One best answer - the others represent common mistakes or partial truths.

Service Scenario

An open-ended situation drawn from the chapter's key service moment. Write freely, then review against your own experience.

Skills Checklist

Five statements about the chapter's core skills. Tick what you own, circle what you're working on. Return after your next shift.

Answers to the Knowledge Check are in the Answer Key at the back, with a brief explanation of why each answer is correct and what makes the wrong answers wrong.

CHAPTER 1

The Heat Returns

Buenos Aires, Argentina - Palermo / a parrilla off Gurruchaga

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Luca arrives at Ezeiza in late January and settles into a Palermo Hollywood apartment before texting Sofia, who is still finishing a late shift in Bangkok. Walking the restless midnight streets, he finds a parrilla by smell and stands across the road watching a family of three generations dine around a grandfather at the head of the table. He studies the floor staff - four servers who engage the room rather than manage it - and turns the central table over in his mind as "a room within the room," recalling William Daniels and choosing not to write the observation down until it has finished becoming what it is.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

- 1. A parrilla, the kind of restaurant Luca watches across the street, is built around:**
 - A) A wood-fired grill where meat is cooked over coals
 - B) A raw seafood bar with tableside shucking
 - C) A tasting-menu kitchen with no visible pass
 - D) A standing-room tapas counter
- 2. Luca notes the Buenos Aires servers move differently from Tokyo or Paris because they:**
 - A) Glide with self-erasing efficiency
 - B) Assert presence as authority the moment they enter a section
 - C) Engage the room directly and physically rather than managing it
 - D) Follow a rigid clockwise service rotation
- 3. Reading a large multi-generation table before you approach means understanding:**
 - A) Only who is paying the bill
 - B) The table's internal structure - who to acknowledge first and how much language to use
 - C) The exact order each guest will finish eating
 - D) Which wines they can afford
- 4. The grandfather acknowledges his regular server with a nod. In hospitality terms this signals:**
 - A) A complaint about the service
 - B) A request to bring the check
 - C) That he is a first-time visitor
 - D) An established relationship and history between guest and house

SERVICE SCENARIO

You are assigned a large family table spanning three generations, anchored by an elder at the head who clearly holds the room. They are mid-conversation and have not signalled for you yet.

Walk through how you read the table's structure before you approach, who you acknowledge first, and how you decide whether they want attention or space - and explain why each read matters.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I read a table's internal structure before I approach - who leads, who is celebrating, who wants to be left alone
- ☐ I recognise and quietly honour returning guests and their history with the house
- ☐ I engage a room directly and warmly rather than hovering or self-erasing
- ☐ I notice a guest's need on one pass and act on it by the next without being asked
- ☐ I hold an observation until I understand it, instead of forcing a conclusion too early

CHAPTER 2

Don Julio

Buenos Aires, Argentina - Don Julio (parrilla, est. 1999)

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Sofia lands in Buenos Aires and joins Don Julio, learning that here warmth is the structure and the floor staff are hosts of a house that happens to be a restaurant. On her third dinner service a grandfather at table seven rejects a 2019 Catena Zapata Malbec as too young; Sofia agrees, reframes, and swaps it for a 2016 that has been open an hour, then quietly tops up the overlooked grandmother's glass and sets the label in the grandfather's sightline without explaining herself. Watching from the bar, Luca writes the three words that name what she did: "Agree. Reframe. Disappear."

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. The grandfather rejects the 2019 Catena Zapata Malbec because:

- A) It is corked and smells of wet cardboard
- B) It is served too warm for the room
- C) It is too young - the oak has not yet integrated
- D) It is the wrong grape variety for the meal

2. The high-altitude Adrianna Vineyard fruit (around 1,450 metres in Lujan de Cuyo) tends to produce Malbec with:

- A) Broad, warm, low-acid tannins
- B) Fine, close-grained tannins and firm acid structure
- C) No tannin and high residual sugar
- D) A deliberately oxidative, sherry-like character

3. Luca distils Sofia's handling of the grandfather into which principle?

- A) Agree, reframe, disappear
- B) Apologise, replace, comp
- C) Listen, defend, escalate
- D) Explain, justify, retreat

4. After swapping the bottle, Sofia sets the label facing the grandfather's sightline. The reason is:

- A) To upsell him a second bottle
- B) To signal the runner which wine was poured
- C) To display the price on the label
- D) To let him read it and draw his own conclusion in his own time

SERVICE SCENARIO

A knowledgeable older guest returns a young red, saying it is not right - and he is bracing for an argument. You taste the objection and agree with it. You have an older vintage of the same wine that has been open and breathing for over an hour.

Walk through exactly what you say, how you reframe the swap without apologising or over-explaining, and what you do for the rest of that table while the guest decides on his own terms.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I agree with a valid objection instead of defending the pour
- ☐ I reframe a wine problem into a better option without apologising or over-explaining
- ☐ I know how bottle age and open time change a wine's oak integration and drinkability
- ☐ I notice and quietly serve the overlooked guest at a table, not just the one who spoke
- ☐ I disappear after a save and let the guest feel the decision was theirs

CHAPTER 3

The First Night

Buenos Aires, Argentina - the Palermo apartment

CHAPTER SUMMARY

After a late close - a section-three table that kept ordering wine until the sommelier pretended he was out of Malbec - Sofia comes home to Luca at the window. This chapter is largely personal: the first night they are finally in the same room with no floor between them and no early flight to break it. Between the intimacy, Luca articulates what William meant about a server who makes people feel seen - that it is something underneath technique, the sense that people matter, which you cannot train.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

- Sofia recounts a closing table that "kept ordering wine until the sommelier had to pretend he was out of the Malbec." This is an example of:**
 - A guest being cut off outright for intoxication
 - A stock shortage in the cellar
 - Upselling a more expensive bottle
 - A soft, face-saving way to slow a table's consumption
- Luca defines the quality William prized - making people feel seen - as:**
 - Something underneath technique that makes people feel they matter
 - A memorised script every server can deliver
 - Pure speed and table-turn efficiency
 - The most expensive upsell on the list
- Sofia says the reality of being together "feels like we finally stopped running." In service terms, presence over performance means:**
 - Performing warmth on a schedule
 - Attending fully to what is in front of you rather than putting on a show
 - Filling every silence with talk
 - Following the steps of service exactly regardless of the guest
- Sofia describes how she assesses the night the way she assesses a service:**
 - By comparing it only to other people's nights
 - By ignoring what went wrong to protect her mood
 - Honestly, noting where expectation was exceeded and where it fell short
 - By writing a formal report immediately

SERVICE SCENARIO

A late table in your section keeps ordering more wine, and you sense they have had enough to compromise the rest of their night. Nothing has gone wrong yet, but you need to slow the pace without embarrassing them or killing the mood.

Walk through how you handle it - what you say, how you protect the guests' dignity, and how you decide when a soft slowdown is the right call.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I can slow a table's alcohol consumption gently, protecting the guest's dignity
- ☐ I lead with genuine presence rather than performed warmth
- ☐ I treat "making a guest feel seen" as care underneath technique, not a script
- ☐ I review my own service honestly, noting both what exceeded and what fell short
- ☐ I stay attentive to a guest's real state instead of only following the steps of service

CHAPTER 4

What We're Building

Buenos Aires, Argentina - Don Julio / the Palermo apartment

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Coaching a talented junior named Valentina on a busy Thursday lunch, Sofia teaches her to read a guest's readiness by menu position - flat means decided, held in both hands means still choosing, resting on the reading glasses means she has decided but will let him take his time. Valentina waits the thirty-second hold, approaches at the right moment, and then writes the lesson down on the back of her notepad, which is the behavior that snags in Luca and Sofia's thinking. After a brutal compounding service that leaves Valentina hollowed, the couple decide to build something that teaches these frameworks on purpose rather than by getting yelled at, naming the goal: "What does it look like when someone finally sees it?"

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. In Sofia's menu-position read, a guest holding the menu in both hands with elbows on the table means:

- A) Still choosing - do not approach yet
- B) Decided and ready to order
- C) Unhappy with the menu
- D) Ready for the check

2. The woman rests her menu on top of her closed reading glasses. Sofia reads this as:

- A) She wants a wine recommendation
- B) She is ready to complain
- C) She has not looked at the menu at all
- D) She has decided but is giving her partner time to choose

3. Sofia teaches the "thirty-second hold" so that the server:

- A) Always waits exactly thirty seconds at every table
- B) Approaches only once the guest shows the release of a made decision
- C) Delays service to appear less eager
- D) Gives the kitchen time to catch up

4. What convinces Sofia and Luca that Valentina truly learned the lesson?

- A) She thanked Sofia politely
- B) She repeated it back word for word
- C) She wrote it down on the back of her notepad in her own words
- D) She used it perfectly on the first try

SERVICE SCENARIO

You are mentoring a fast, talented new server who has strong instincts but no framework, so she approaches tables at the wrong moment and gets corrected the hard way. You want to teach her to read a guest's readiness before she arrives.

Walk through how you would demonstrate the menu-position read and the timing hold, and how you would help her keep the lesson rather than just witness it.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I read a guest's readiness to order from menu position and body language before I approach
- ☐ I wait for the release of a decision instead of arriving too early and rushing the guest
- ☐ I mentor newer staff by demonstrating and naming the why, not just correcting the what
- ☐ I recognise that the guest who defers wants their companion to choose, and I serve accordingly
- ☐ I write down and translate what works into my own language so I can repeat and teach it

CHAPTER 5

A Day in the City

Buenos Aires, Argentina - Palermo market, Recoleta, a cafe terrace

CHAPTER SUMMARY

On a rare shared Sunday off in February, Sofia and Luca wander Palermo Viejo, buy figs and warm bread and local cheese at an unfussy market, and walk the Recoleta Cemetery photographing the low light on the marble. Over a bottle of Malbec at a cafe they trade "worst property" stories - her Dubai hotel that hand-measured collars daily, his Maldives resort with eleven laminated axioms and a monthly quiz - laughing at management that mistook rules and uniforms for hospitality. On the balcony that night Sofia admits how much she wants this and her habit of pre-planning the ending, and they decide to keep going.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Sofia and Luca's "worst property" stories share a common failure of management:

- A) Underpaying staff
- B) Poor kitchen equipment
- C) Confusing rules, uniforms, and slogans with actual hospitality
- D) Overbooking the dining room

2. Their reflection on the old hotels that "kept working" is that the survivors:

- A) Never changed anything at all
- B) Figured out what they were actually for
- C) Spent the most on marble and decoration
- D) Had the strictest rulebooks

3. The Malbec at the cafe is described approvingly as:

- A) Performing importance with heavy oak
- B) A cheap house pour with no character
- C) Too young to drink
- D) Just wine with some depth to it, not performing anything

4. Sofia admits she has become very good at a particular professional habit that now bleeds into her personal life:

- A) Being ready to leave - planning the ending in advance
- B) Upselling premium bottles
- C) Memorising every guest's name
- D) Working double shifts without rest

SERVICE SCENARIO

A new manager wants to raise standards and proposes a rulebook of slogans, daily uniform checks, and a monthly quiz. You have worked places that ran on exactly that and watched it hollow out the floor.

Explain how you would push back constructively - what genuinely raises service quality versus what only performs control - and what you would put in place instead.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I distinguish genuine hospitality from surface control like slogans, quizzes, and uniform rituals
- ☐ I judge a wine or a service by its substance, not its performance of importance
- ☐ I understand what a venue is actually for and let that guide how I serve
- ☐ I notice when professional habits like "always ready to leave" affect my presence
- ☐ I can name the difference between rules that help guests and rules that only serve management

CHAPTER 6

The Visa Question

Buenos Aires, Argentina - Don Julio / the Palermo apartment

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Sofia gets word that her Argentine work visa extension may not clear before it expires in six weeks, and she carries the news through a demanding Tuesday lunch - a party of twelve arriving thirty minutes late while the kitchen runs behind on the tira de asado after a wrong-cut delivery. When the host implies their lateness may have caused problems, she reframes with "The kitchen paces to the table - you're right on time," giving the sentence nowhere to push against. Afterward she names the hardest part of the job: protecting the room from whatever is happening inside you, and that night she and Luca decide to face the next city together rather than separately.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. A guest who arrived late hints that the delay may have "created complications." Sofia's reply, "The kitchen paces to the table - you're right on time," works because it:

- A) Blames the kitchen for the wait
- B) Offers a discount to smooth things over
- C) Ignores the guest completely
- D) Describes a reality in which his lateness is already accounted for, leaving nothing to argue

2. When the kitchen falls behind, Sofia manages the twelve-top before the host can lift his hand by:

- A) Proactively buying time with a graceful line and keeping the runner on water
- B) Announcing the delay and apologising to the whole table
- C) Rushing out unfinished courses
- D) Avoiding the table until the food is ready

3. Sofia concludes the hardest thing about the job is:

- A) Memorising the wine list
- B) Learning to protect the room from whatever is happening inside you
- C) Carrying four plates at once
- D) Splitting a complicated bill

4. She describes this protection as:

- A) Passive endurance - suffering privately while performing normalcy
- B) Something only managers need
- C) An active, deployable skill, like timing a course or reading a table
- D) A sign she should take the night off

SERVICE SCENARIO

You are carrying difficult personal news into a busy shift, and a large party arrives late just as the kitchen falls behind. The host begins to imply the delay is a problem.

Walk through how you keep your inner state off the floor, how you reframe the guest's implication so it has nowhere to push against, and how you buy the kitchen time without apologising or serving unfinished food.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I keep my personal state entirely off my face, pace, and service on the floor
- ☐ I reframe a guest's complaint so it has nothing left to push against
- ☐ I buy the kitchen time gracefully by managing pace and keeping guests comfortable
- ☐ I approach a table proactively before frustration can surface
- ☐ I treat composure as an active, trainable skill rather than silent endurance

CHAPTER 7

Sydney

Sydney, Australia - Quay (Circular Quay) / Saint Peter (Oxford Street)

CHAPTER SUMMARY

After the visa extension is denied, Sofia and Luca relocate to Potts Point; he starts at Quay, where the room rewards composed deceleration, and she starts at Josh Niland's Saint Peter, learning whole-fish knowledge. Luca coaches a talented but visibly-effortful server, Jamie, on the sightline principle - his elbow crossed a guest's line of sight mid-sentence, so he teaches approaching from the guest's left, tray low, arcing around occupied sightlines - and Jamie earns a note reading "Impeccable." Sofia retrains the runners to stop saying a fish is "bony" and instead describe bone structure as architecture: "That's not spin. That's translation," and over late nights the project finally gets a name - ServeMaster.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Luca teaches Jamie that a clean tray carry is really about:

- A) Weight distribution and carry angle
- B) Sightlines - knowing where everyone is looking before you move
- C) Speed - getting plates down as fast as possible
- D) Announcing each dish loudly

2. The rule Luca gives for approaching a table in conversation is:

- A) Approach from the right, at shoulder height
- B) Always approach from directly behind
- C) Approach from the guest's left, tray below the seated eye line, arcing around occupied sightlines
- D) Approach fastest, from whichever side is closest

3. At Saint Peter, Sofia retrains the runners to stop calling a fish "bony" because:

- A) The word reads as an apology or warning; describing bone structure as architecture is translation, not spin
- B) The word is factually incorrect
- C) Guests prefer no description at all
- D) It slows down service

4. Josh Niland's Saint Peter is known for applying to fish the philosophy of:

- A) Sous-vide precision cooking
- B) Molecular gastronomy and foams
- C) Purely raw, sashimi-style service
- D) Nose-to-tail (whole-fish) use, treating bones and all parts as intentional

SERVICE SCENARIO

A talented server on your floor sets plates down technically well but keeps crossing guests' sightlines during conversation, subtly interrupting them. The guests never complain out loud.

Walk through how you would show this server the sightline principle - the side to approach from, the tray height, the arc around occupied eyelines - and how you would explain why three extra steps beat one interrupted sentence.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I approach tables from the guest's left with the tray below the seated eye line
- ☐ I map where everyone is looking before I move, so my service stays invisible
- ☐ I go around an occupied sightline rather than cutting across a conversation
- ☐ I translate a guest's fear into confident language instead of apologising with warning words
- ☐ I can speak accurately about how a product is made - including whole-fish structure and texture

CHAPTER 8

The Harbour

Sydney, Australia - Potts Point / Circular Quay promenade

CHAPTER SUMMARY

On a slow Sunday, Sofia and Luca walk the harbour and clarify the philosophy behind their project: you cannot command someone to make guests feel seen, but you can teach the conditions - the hold, the sightline, the translation - that make the feeling possible. Reflecting on Saint Peter, Sofia realises guests say "bony" when they mean an unnamed fear of embarrassing themselves, so the job is to respond to the fear under the word, not the word. When she stumbles toward framing the lessons, Luca names it exactly - "The module is the word, not the action" - and they agree they are done "almosting."

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

- The couple's core insight about "making guests feel seen" is that you:**
 - Cannot teach it directly, but you can teach the conditions that make it possible
 - Can command it directly from staff
 - Should print it on motivational cards
 - Only need to hire naturally warm people
- Sofia decides that when a guest says "bony," the server should:**
 - Correct the guest's word choice
 - Remove the dish and offer a fillet
 - Reassure them the fish is fine and move on
 - Respond to the fear under the word, not the word itself
- Luca's phrase "The module is the word, not the action" means the training should give servers:**
 - A list of exact actions to memorise
 - Faster ways to turn tables
 - Vocabulary for things they already know how to do but cannot yet name
 - Strict scripts for every table
- A refinement one Saint Peter runner adds is that the reassuring word must be available:**
 - Only at the moment of ordering
 - At the moment the fear returns, which may be mid-meal or after an initial success
 - Only in writing on the menu
 - Only when the guest asks twice

SERVICE SCENARIO

Your training program keeps telling staff to "make guests feel seen" and "be present," but the words are not changing how anyone actually serves. You want to teach it in a way that works.

Explain how you would teach the conditions rather than the command - concrete skills like the timing hold, the sightline, and translating a guest's unnamed fear - and how giving people vocabulary changes their behavior.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I respond to the fear underneath a guest's words, not just the literal words
- ☐ I teach concrete conditions - timing, sightlines, translation - rather than commanding feelings
- ☐ I give guests and staff language for what they already sense but cannot name
- ☐ I keep a reassuring frame ready for when a guest's anxiety resurfaces mid-meal
- ☐ I treat "feeling seen" as the result of teachable conditions, not a slogan

CHAPTER 9

Melbourne

Melbourne, Australia - Gimlet (CBD) / Attica / a Richmond restaurant

CHAPTER SUMMARY

In Melbourne, Sofia works at Andrew McConnell's Gimlet and coaches a strong server, Priya, to see upselling as editing - read whether the guest's hesitation is decision-making or anxiety, ask one diagnostic question ("Is tonight a celebration or a Tuesday?"), and offer one specific wine by name in sensory terms. Priya recommends the Giaconda Naerock, the guest relaxes and spends more, and later raises a real grievance about a tip-out structure that punishes servers on slow nights. Sofia also observes Marcus Hale's Richmond room - flawless, controlled, silent with caution - and concludes that control and trust are not the same thing: his guests are served correctly, tip adequately, and leave before dessert.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Sofia reframes upselling for Priya as:

- A) Selling the most expensive bottle every time
- B) Waiting until the guest asks for help
- C) Editing - using your knowledge to guide the guest to the right choice faster
- D) Reciting the full wine list

2. Priya's effective diagnostic question, "Is tonight a celebration or a Tuesday?", works because it:

- A) Locates the guest emotionally and answers the real question, not the stated one
- B) Narrows the guest to a price range
- C) Tests the guest's wine knowledge
- D) Forces a quick yes or no

3. Sofia's three-step upsell principle is: read the anxiety, ask one diagnostic question, then:

- A) Offer a category of wine to choose from
- B) List three options at different prices
- C) Let the guest keep reading the list
- D) Recommend one specific wine by name in sensory terms

4. Observing Marcus Hale's controlled Richmond floor, Sofia concludes that:

- A) Control and trust are the same result
- B) Control and trust are different - his room serves the system, and guests feel it and leave before dessert
- C) Strict control always produces the best guest experience
- D) The problem was only the food

SERVICE SCENARIO

A guest at your table has been staring at the wine list for several minutes and looks tense rather than engaged. You want to help without it feeling like a pushy sale.

Walk through how you tell decision-making from anxiety, the one diagnostic question you would ask, and the single specific recommendation you would make - and explain why this is editing, not selling.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I tell the difference between a guest deciding and a guest who is anxious
- ☐ I ask one diagnostic question that opens a guest up rather than narrowing them down
- ☐ I recommend one specific wine by name in sensory terms instead of offering a category
- ☐ I treat upselling as editing toward the guest's best night, not pushing the priciest bottle
- ☐ I understand that a controlled room and a trusted room produce very different guest experiences

CHAPTER 10

The Table We Want

Melbourne, Australia - Royal Botanic Gardens / Attica

CHAPTER SUMMARY

On a rare blue afternoon in the Botanic Gardens, Sofia and Luca write the Lee family scenario: a disclosed shellfish allergy handled so the guest is never asked to identify themselves a third time. Luca intercepts the runner at the service door ("I own nine"), places the adjusted plate himself without comment, and tells the daughter "I have your mum's shellfish note - she won't have to repeat it," yielding the principle "Never make a guest become a medical document in public." The bigger breakthrough is realising they should teach lenses, not rules - "read the system the people have become" rather than "read the table" - because a lens lets a server improvise in rooms and situations no rule ever covered.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. In the Lee family scenario, the failure Luca prevents is:

- A) Serving the wrong wine
- B) Asking the allergy guest to identify her restriction yet again, in public
- C) Bringing the plates too slowly
- D) Charging for an extra course

2. Best practice for a disclosed allergy, as the scenario models it, is that the information:

- A) Is confirmed fresh with the guest at every course
- B) Is left to the runner to ask about at the table
- C) Is only acted on if the guest reminds staff
- D) Is logged at reservation, communicated to the kitchen and floor, and handled without making the guest repeat it

3. The distinction between a "tip" and a "lens" is that a lens:

- A) Teaches you how to see, so you generate the right move in situations no rule covered
- B) Tells you exactly what to do in one situation
- C) Is faster to memorise than a tip
- D) Only applies to allergy handling

4. The lens Luca prefers to "read the table" is:

- A) Read the bill
- B) Read the reservation notes only
- C) Read the system the people have become - the temporary social system with its own agreements
- D) Read the menu back to them

SERVICE SCENARIO

A table has disclosed a serious shellfish allergy at booking, and it has been logged and passed to the kitchen. During service a runner is about to approach and ask, once again, "Who had the shellfish?"

Walk through how you intercept and handle the plate so the guest is never made to repeat her restriction in public, and explain the principle behind why that protection matters.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I ensure a disclosed allergy is logged, communicated, and handled without making the guest repeat it
- ☐ I intercept avoidable errors at the service door before they reach the table
- ☐ I never make a guest become a medical document in public
- ☐ I read a table as a social system, not just a set of individuals
- ☐ I work from lenses that let me improvise correctly, not rigid one-situation rules

CHAPTER 11

The Parting

Melbourne, Australia - the Fitzroy apartment

CHAPTER SUMMARY

A serious six-month offer from a newly starred Singapore restaurant arrives on an ordinary Wednesday, and Luca - understanding that shrinking her would be fear wearing the clothes of love - tells Sofia she should take it, and they decide to keep building across the distance. Over their remaining six weeks they refine the work, including Sofia's insistence that the Lee family scenario should "name the split" between a table's emotional register and its service mechanics rather than pretend a server can be seamless about doing two difficult jobs at once. On the last night they cook simply and go, choosing not a farewell scene but their worn phrase, "No more almosts."

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

- Sofia argues the Lee family scenario should "name the split" between:**
 - The emotional register of the table and the service mechanics - two jobs, not one
 - The kitchen and the bar
 - Lunch service and dinner service
 - The host and the runner
- Why does naming the split matter for how servers judge themselves?**
 - It lets them skip the harder job
 - It shifts blame to the kitchen
 - It stops them from thinking they failed when they actually did two difficult things at once
 - It makes service faster
- Priya, Sofia reports, has grown by finding the part of the work that fits her, specifically:**
 - Managing the wine cellar
 - Running the pass
 - Training new hires
 - The personal ritual element of service
- Luca and Sofia choose to keep their notebook loop alive across the distance by:**
 - Pausing the project until they reunite
 - Luca writing down what he notices and telling her when they call, every night
 - Hiring someone to observe for them
 - Only working on it in person

SERVICE SCENARIO

You are training a server who feels they "failed" a birthday table because they had to juggle the celebration's mood and the mechanics of allergy-safe, well-timed service at the same time.

Explain how you would name the split between emotional register and service mechanics, and how framing it as two hard jobs - not one easy one - changes how the server judges their own performance.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I recognise that holding a table's mood and its service mechanics are two distinct jobs
- ☐ I frame imperfect service honestly so staff do not mistake two hard jobs for one failed easy one
- ☐ I help servers find and develop the part of the work that fits them
- ☐ I keep an observation-and-notes loop going even when a teammate is not present
- ☐ I make hard staffing and career decisions from respect rather than from fear disguised as protection

CHAPTER 12

The Seed

Melbourne, Australia - Royal Botanic Gardens (final night)

CHAPTER SUMMARY

On Sofia's last night before flying to Singapore, they slip through the gap in the Botanic Gardens fence and stand at the railing above the lit city, and Luca opens the ServeMaster note - forty-seven pages, fifty-three scenarios, each with a single lens statement and the guest's experience at every decision point. Reviewing the entries - the Lee family, the grandfather at Don Julio, Jamie and the sightline, Priya and the wine list, Valentina's act of noting - he lands on William's foundation sentence: hospitality's fundamental transaction is recognition, making someone feel seen rather than merely handled. After a full, unhurried goodbye and their phrase "No more almosts," Luca types the opening line of the whole project: "This already exists. We are writing it down."

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. The ServeMaster field guide is built so that each scenario has:

- A) A price and an upsell target
- B) A star rating
- C) A memorised script
- D) A single lens statement plus the guest's experience at each decision point

2. Luca notes their scenarios are deliberately written from which perspective?

- A) The server's, looking out
- B) The guest's, looking in - because guests live on the outside
- C) The kitchen's
- D) The owner's

3. William Daniels's foundation sentence, which every lens must answer to, is that hospitality's fundamental transaction is:

- A) Recognition - making someone feel seen, not handled or processed
- B) Efficiency
- C) Upselling
- D) Speed of turnover

4. The Valentina entry that Luca leaves incomplete circles the idea that guests feel tended to when they:

- A) See the final bill itemised
- B) Are offered a free dessert
- C) See the act of noting - evidence their preferences are being recorded, not just heard
- D) Are seated fastest

SERVICE SCENARIO

You want to capture a great service moment - something a teammate did that made a guest feel genuinely seen - so it can be taught to someone in a city where no mentor exists.

Walk through how you would write it as a lens: the single sentence naming what it is really about, and a description of what the guest experienced at each decision point from their side of the table.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I treat recognition - making a guest feel seen, not handled - as the core of hospitality
- ☐ I capture what works as a single lens statement rather than a one-off tip
- ☐ I describe service from the guest's perspective, looking in, when I teach or review it
- ☐ I let a guest see the act of noting so they know their preferences are recorded
- ☐ I write down what I learn so it can reach people who have no mentor of their own

ANSWER KEY

Knowledge Check Answers

With explanations.

Ch. 1 - THE HEAT RETURNS

1. Answer: A) A wood-fired grill where meat is cooked over coals

A parrilla cooks meat over a wood fire - Luca notes the coals are wood, not gas, because the quality of the light moves. The other formats do not match the fire-and-char scene he describes.

2. Answer: C) Engage the room directly and physically rather than managing it

He contrasts Tokyo's spatial courtesy and Paris's presence-as-authority with a more direct, physical engagement here. The server catches an eye on one pass and stops at that table on the return as if the stop was always the route.

3. Answer: B) The table's internal structure - who to acknowledge first and how much language to use

Luca frames real service as reading the table's social architecture first - who leads, whether they want to be seen or left alone - so the approach fits. Guessing at the bill or the pace misses the point.

4. Answer: D) An established relationship and history between guest and house

The nod carries an entire relationship's worth of history - this is not the first time the man has eaten in the room, and both know it. Recognising returning guests is a core hospitality skill.

Ch. 2 - DON JULIO

1. Answer: C) It is too young - the oak has not yet integrated

Sofia agrees it is too young - at six years the oak's vanilla and cedar are still "biographical," announcing their origin rather than dissolving into the wine. That is a maturity issue, not a fault like cork taint or temperature.

2. Answer: B) Fine, close-grained tannins and firm acid structure

Thinner, cooler high-altitude air ripens the vines slowly, building acid and fine, close-grained tannins - the opposite of the broader, warmer tannins found at lower elevation.

3. Answer: A) Agree, reframe, disappear

He writes "Agree. Reframe. Disappear." - and adds that you never explain what you just did, because the guest needs to feel they decided. Apologising or explaining would undo the effect.

4. Answer: D) To let him read it and draw his own conclusion in his own time

She places the label so he can see it when he chooses - he decides on his own terms. Explaining or pushing a second bottle would have ruined the moment she built.

Ch. 3 - THE FIRST NIGHT

1. Answer: D) A soft, face-saving way to slow a table's consumption

Claiming to be "out" is a gentle, dignity-preserving way to slow a table - the wine was not actually gone. It is neither a hard cut-off nor a real shortage.

2. Answer: A) Something underneath technique that makes people feel they matter

He concludes it is "something underneath the technique" - the way you make people feel they matter - and that you either have it or you do not. It is not a script or a speed metric.

3. Answer: B) Attending fully to what is in front of you rather than putting on a show

She notices the absence of performance the way you notice a room without background music - care that exists because the thing matters, not because it is required. That is presence, not performance.

4. Answer: C) Honestly, noting where expectation was exceeded and where it fell short

She takes stock without flattery - the exceeding is where the learning is, the falling short is where you get better. Ignoring faults or refusing honest review is the opposite of her method.

Ch. 4 - WHAT WE'RE BUILDING

1. Answer: A) Still choosing - do not approach yet

Held in both hands means still choosing; flat on the table means decided. Approaching too early would make the guest feel rushed into the wrong order.

2. Answer: D) She has decided but is giving her partner time to choose

Menu on the glasses means she is decided but will let him take his time - he needs to be the one who chooses. It is her signal to the server, not a request or a complaint.

3. Answer: B) Approaches only once the guest shows the release of a made decision

The hold is about reading the moment the decision lands - the man's shoulders drop and he sets the menu flat - not a rigid timer or a stall for the kitchen.

4. Answer: C) She wrote it down on the back of her notepad in her own words

The turn to the blank page and the private act of transcription - translating the lesson into her own terms - is the behavior that matters, more than a polite thanks or flawless first use.

1. Answer: C) Confusing rules, uniforms, and slogans with actual hospitality

The hand-measured collars and the laminated axioms with a monthly quiz both mistake surface control for genuine service. That is the shared joke and the shared critique.

2. Answer: B) Figured out what they were actually for

Luca says the ones that made it "figured out what they were actually for" - purpose, not ornament or rigid rules, is what let them keep working.

3. Answer: D) Just wine with some depth to it, not performing anything

It is praised as "not performing anything, just wine with some depth to it" - the same present-over-performance value they prize in service.

4. Answer: A) Being ready to leave - planning the ending in advance

Years of contracts and placements trained her to "be ready to leave," and she catches herself already making contingency plans for the relationship. It is about impermanence, not upselling or memory.

Ch. 6 - THE VISA QUESTION

1. Answer: D) Describes a reality in which his lateness is already accounted for, leaving nothing to argue

The line reframes so his lateness is retroactively not a problem - the sentence has nowhere to push against. It neither blames the kitchen nor buys him off.

2. Answer: A) Proactively buying time with a graceful line and keeping the runner on water

She reaches the table first, frames a pause between courses positively, and keeps Mateo on water - anticipatory management, not an apology or half-cooked food.

3. Answer: B) Learning to protect the room from whatever is happening inside you

She realises the real difficulty is active protection - keeping her own turmoil, like the visa news, entirely off her face, pace, and service. It is a built skill, not endurance.

4. Answer: C) An active, deployable skill, like timing a course or reading a table

She names it as active and refined - a skill she can deploy with precision - not mere endurance. A good server is always in two places at once: present in the room, carrying something outside it the room must never feel.

Ch. 7 - SYDNEY

1. Answer: B) Sightlines - knowing where everyone is looking before you move

The tray is a sightline problem, not a logistics one - Jamie's elbow crossed a guest's line of sight mid-sentence and broke her thread. Invisibility means knowing where eyes are before you move.

2. Answer: C) Approach from the guest's left, tray below the seated eye line, arcing around occupied sightlines

Guest's left, tray low below the seated eye line, and never cross an occupied sightline on a first pass - go around even if it costs three steps. An interrupted sentence is worse than three steps.

3. Answer: A) The word reads as an apology or warning; describing bone structure as architecture is translation, not spin

People hear "bony" as a warning of a flaw. Reframing bones as the architecture the flesh organises around gives them a different word for the thing they fear - translation, not spin.

4. Answer: D) Nose-to-tail (whole-fish) use, treating bones and all parts as intentional

Saint Peter built its reputation on whole-fish, nose-to-tail thinking - dry-aging, using every part - which is why the floor must speak accurately about texture, fat, and bone structure.

Ch. 8 - THE HARBOUR

1. Answer: A) Cannot teach it directly, but you can teach the conditions that make it possible

You cannot order someone to care, but the hold, the sightline, and the translation create a situation where the feeling becomes possible for guest and server alike. Slogans and hiring alone do not do it.

2. Answer: D) Respond to the fear under the word, not the word itself

The word carries an unnamed fear - embarrassment about eating it "properly." Responding to the fear, by making the bone structure interesting before anyone can dread it, is the real service.

3. Answer: C) Vocabulary for things they already know how to do but cannot yet name

The modules give people language for intuitions they already have, so they can hold and repeat them - not a rote action list or a table-turn metric.

4. Answer: B) At the moment the fear returns, which may be mid-meal or after an initial success

The runner maps that the fear can resurface mid-meal or on the second course, so the translation has to be ready when the fear returns, not just at the start.

Ch. 9 - MELBOURNE

1. Answer: C) Editing - using your knowledge to guide the guest to the right choice faster

You are not selling, you are editing: the guest arrived with too many options and you help them reach the best one. Pushing the priciest bottle or waiting passively both miss it.

2. Answer: A) Locates the guest emotionally and answers the real question, not the stated one

It opens the guest up and locates them emotionally - the man's real anxiety was whether the night was worth the price, and

3. Answer: D) Recommend one specific wine by name in sensory terms

The guest needs a name, not a category - one specific recommendation described in sensory terms, like the Giaconda Naerock that would "make the duck sing." A category just prolongs the anxiety.

4. Answer: B) Control and trust are different - his room serves the system, and guests feel it and leave before dessert

A flawless, controlled room served for the manager, not the guest - the guests stayed polite, tipped adequately, and left before dessert. Control is not the same as the trust that makes guests relax.

Ch. 10 - THE TABLE WE WANT

1. Answer: B) Asking the allergy guest to identify her restriction yet again, in public

The allergy was disclosed at reservation and logged; asking again during service would force Mrs. Lee to become "a medical document in public." Luca intercepts so she never has to repeat it.

2. Answer: D) Is logged at reservation, communicated to the kitchen and floor, and handled without making the guest repeat it

The allergy is logged at reservation, passed to kitchen and floor, and the adjusted plate is placed without asking - the guest experiences that someone was paying attention all along, not repeated interrogation.

3. Answer: A) Teaches you how to see, so you generate the right move in situations no rule covered

A tip prescribes one action for one configuration; a lens changes how you see so you can improvise correctly in a room you have never worked. That is why "lenses, not rules" becomes the whole approach.

4. Answer: C) Read the system the people have become - the temporary social system with its own agreements

Tables are temporary social systems with internal agreements about who leads, who is celebrating, who needs the next drink. "Read the table" means almost nothing; reading the system does the work.

Ch. 11 - THE PARTING

1. Answer: A) The emotional register of the table and the service mechanics - two jobs, not one

She insists holding a table's emotional register and its service mechanics are two different jobs; pretending they are one makes servers feel they failed when they simply did two hard things imperfectly.

2. Answer: C) It stops them from thinking they failed when they actually did two difficult things at once

Honest framing keeps a server from thinking they failed at "one easy thing" when they were really managing two demanding jobs simultaneously. It protects morale and accuracy.

3. Answer: D) The personal ritual element of service

Sofia says Priya "went deep" on the personal ritual element and is already good at it - the satisfaction of a server locating herself inside the work.

4. Answer: B) Luca writing down what he notices and telling her when they call, every night

When Sofia worries the observation loop breaks without her watching, Luca commits to writing it down and telling her every night on their call - the work does not require the same room.

Ch. 12 - THE SEED

1. Answer: D) A single lens statement plus the guest's experience at each decision point

Each of the fifty-three scenarios carries one lens sentence naming what it is about, and describes what the guest experienced at each decision point - written from the outside looking in.

2. Answer: B) The guest's, looking in - because guests live on the outside

The whole problem with most training is that it is written from the inside looking out; ServeMaster writes from the guest's perspective because guests live on the outside looking in.

3. Answer: A) Recognition - making someone feel seen, not handled or processed

William teaches the core transaction is recognition: not food, wine, or comfort, but making someone feel seen rather than handled or efficiently accommodated. Every scenario is tested against it.

4. Answer: C) See the act of noting - evidence their preferences are being recorded, not just heard

The partial lens reads: "The guest does not need to see the notes. They need to see the act of noting." - visible recording signals that their preferences are truly registered.

Keep going.

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of hospitality professionals.